



386 CE TOBA WEI REUNIFY NORTHERN CHINA

The chaotic 16 Kingdoms period began to resolve itself in 386 CE when the Toba – a non-Han Chinese Turkic people – asserted their independence. Their ruler Toba Gui declared himself first emperor of the Wei dynasty in 399 CE and began an expansion of Toba territory that within 40 years reunified northern China. The Wei adopted Buddhism and were patrons of Buddhist art.

◁ Buddhist carvings at Yungang Caves, commissioned by the Wei

“The renowned city, the capital of the Roman Empire, is swallowed up in one tremendous fire.”

OROSIUS, LETTER TO GAUDENTIUS, ABOUT THE SACK OF ROME IN 410 CE

404 CE Gwanggaeto, ruler of the Korean state of Silla, defeats an invasion from Yamato Japan

405 CE St Jerome completes the Vulgate translation of the Bible

406 CE Vandals, Sueves, and Alan barbarians cross the Rhine frontier of the Roman Empire in force

419 CE

410 CE GOTHS UNDER ALARIC SACK ROME

Frustrated at years of broken Roman promises of land for his people, the Gothic chieftain Alaric invaded Italy, aiming to capture Rome itself. A first siege was lifted after the payment of a huge tribute, but Emperor Honorius broke off further negotiations and, after a new siege, the Goths broke into the city in August 410 CE, ransacking many of its buildings.

▷ The sack of Rome by Alaric's Goths



400-1700 CE DEVELOPMENT OF CHINESE PAINTING

From the 5th century CE, Chinese artists developed advanced brushwork techniques and established a tradition of landscape painting that endured for centuries.



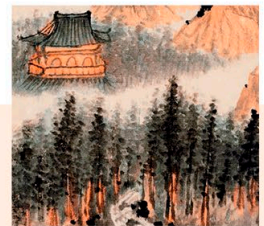
c. 400 CE Gui Kaizhi, a leading artist of the Northern Wei, is among the first major advocates of landscape painting.



c. 750 CE Wang Wei introduces ink and wash landscape painting during the Tang artistic revival.



c. 1500 The “Four Masters of the Ming,” including Shen Zhou, emphasize individual expression and bring Chinese painting to new heights.



1650-1700 Under the early Qing, individualistic painting styles emerge, notably the fluid brushwork of Shitao (above).